

The Alps

The highest and most extensive of Europe's mountain ranges, containing many famous peaks



Some 750 miles (1,200km) long and more than 120 miles (200km) wide at their broadest point, the Alps cover more than 80,000 square miles (207,000 square km) of western Europe. Pushed up over the last 100 million years by the coming together of the African and Eurasian plates, they form a curved belt, with more than 50 peaks rising to over 12,500ft (3,800m).

Shaped by glaciers

The current landscape of the Alps is a result of glaciation over the past 2 million years. The glaciers that once covered these peaks sculpted out enormous amphitheatre-like cirques (mountain hollows), sharp arêtes (knifelike ridges), and majestic pyramidal peaks such as the Matterhorn on the Swiss–Italian border and Austria's highest mountain, Grossglockner. As the glaciers melted, they left behind some



U-shaped valleys, immense waterfalls pouring from hanging valleys, and elongated lakes of great depth. The longest remaining glacier is the Aletsch (see p.151).

European playground

The Alps include famous mountains such as Mont Blanc on the French–Italian border, the Matterhorn, and the Eiger in Switzerland, whose north face has long been considered one of the world's climbing challenges.

During summer, the region attracts mountaineers and people who enjoy hiking, mountain biking, and paragliding. Winter sports such as skiing and snowboarding are also popular.

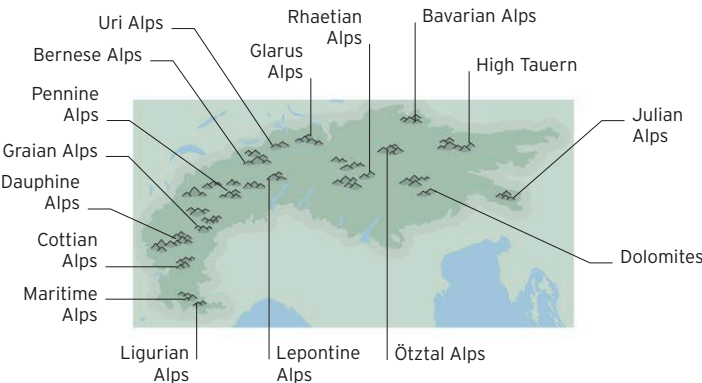
◀ LIVING AT ALTITUDE

A type of large squirrel, the marmot is a common sight in high-altitude pastures during summer. Marmots hibernate for the rest of the year in burrows underground.

In 1991, a **5,000-year-old mummy**, since named **Ötzi**, was **found** in the **Ötztal Alps**

SUBRANGES OF THE ALPS

The Alps contain many subranges, some of which are mapped below. The loftiest are the Pennine Alps, which contain 13 of the highest 20 alpine peaks; the Bernese Alps contain four; and the Mont Blanc Massif in the Graian Alps has three.



▽ FLORAL MIGRATION

As global temperatures have risen and glaciers retreated, flowering plants of all kinds have spread to much higher latitudes and altitudes in the Alps.

